QUICK REFERENCE

Version 1.5 · October 2026 · The full guide governs wherever this sheet is silent. · Build and check footnotes at gmichaelrapp.github.io/OSINT_Cites

THE CITATION PATTERN

Author, "Title," *Location* [Description] (Publisher: Date) URL/DOI: Locator.

Author, *Title*, *Location* [Description] (Publisher: Date) URL/DOI: Locator.

Short works take "quotes"; larger works are *italicized*, or clearly underlined where a platform cannot render italics. Drop a slot that does not apply — and its punctuation with it. Anchor notes at paragraph ends or after a quotation, not after every sentence.

THE EIGHT SLOTS AT A GLANCE

Slot	Rule	Drop it when…
Author	First name then surname; keep surname-first order where it is the person's own (Xi Jinping). 4+ authors → first three + et al. After a semicolon: editors (ed.), then translators (trans.), then contributors (contr.).	Never — fall back to the organization, then the title
Title	"Quotes" for short works, *italics* for larger ones. Mark errors [sic]. Social post: its own words; past about a dozen, cut and add an ellipsis. Not in English: original title, then ["English translation"].	Never — no title, plain description instead
Location	Publication, platform, site, series, or archive. Italicized. ≤10 words (a chapter's containing volume may run longer).	It would repeat the title
[Description]	Kind of source first, from Appendix B (771 descriptions), then the order below. Semicolons between items.	Never — this is the house signature
(Publisher: Date)	One parenthetical, split by a colon. DD Month YYYY for news, social, video, releases; year alone for books, journal articles, and chapters.	Publisher repeats the location — journals, papers, wires. Date: never; use n.d.
URL/DOI : Locator	Full URL, never shortened; DOIs as https://doi.org/…. Then p. / pp. after a colon. Never count paragraphs — cite named sections.	No online version; source has no pages

INSIDE THE BRACKET — ALWAYS IN THIS ORDER

[Kind of source; details; qualifiers; language; access; rating] e.g. [Peer-Reviewed Article; Vol. 38, No. 2; accepted manuscript; original in Chinese; institutional access; B2]

- *Qualifiers* describe this copy, not its kind: leaked · declassified · preprint · retracted · transcript · scan · archived · AI-generated, and others in Appendix B.
- *Journals:* Peer-Reviewed Article only when the journal is known to referee. Otherwise Journal Article plus editor-reviewed · student-edited · not peer-reviewed · review status unclear.
- *Books:* Monograph = scholarly, for specialists, usually a university press. Trade Book = general readers, even by a scholar. Can't tell? Trade Book.
- *Access:* paywalled · metered paywall · free registration required · institutional access · region-restricted · app only. Free to read takes no note.
- *Language:* original in Russian · translation by author · machine translation · translated from Russian (a published translation; credit the translator as trans.). Disclose machine translation; check quotations against the original.

THE MOST-USED FORMS — LINKS CUT SHORT HERE TO SAVE SPACE

Book — Michael Beckley, *Unrivaled: Why America Will Remain the World's Sole Superpower* [Monograph] (Cornell University Press: 2018): pp. 25–27.

News — David Sanger, "U.S. Expands Cyber Operations," *The New York Times* [News Article; B2] (12 February 2026) https://www.nytimes.com/….

Social — OSINTdefender, "Ukrainian Drone Strike Footage Near Bakhmut," *X* [Social Media Post; C3] (14 February 2026) https://x.com/…. Archived: https://archive.ph/abc123 (captured 14 February 2026).

Short form — Beckley, *Unrivaled*, p. 45. · *Immediate repeat* — Ibid., p. 51. (Locators take a colon in a full citation, a comma in a short form.)

VOLATILE SOURCES — NON-NEGOTIABLE

- Archive every social post, Telegram/Discord item, blog, and revisable page *at capture*. Append: Archived: URL (captured DD Month YYYY).
- Add an access date to anything continuously updated: sanctions lists, trackers, registries, dashboards.
- A screenshot you did not observe live is a *secondary* citation. Open with "Cited in." Unknown provenance is F6.
- AI model output is *F6 by default*. Cite model and version, retain the transcript, never let it carry a factual claim. Disclose analytic use in the piece.

SOURCE RATING — LETTERS RATE THE SOURCE, NUMBERS RATE THE INFORMATION

Cred ↓ / Rel →	A	B	C	D	E	F	A Highly Reliable · B Usually · C Fairly · D Not Usually · E Unreliable · F Unknown
1	A1	B1	C1	D1	E1	F1	1 Confirmed · 2 Probable · 3 Possible
2	A2	B2	C2	D2	E2	F2	4 Doubtful · 5 Improbable · 6 Unknown
3	A3	B3	C3	D3	E3	F3	GREEN — core evidence
4	A4	B4	C4	D4	E4	F4	YELLOW — frame and corroborate
5	A5	B5	C5	D5	E5	F5	ORANGE — weak; caveat in a footnote
6	A6	B6	C6	D6	E6	F6	RED — cite only to challenge a claim · GRAY — shows a claim circulates; never sole support

ESTIMATIVE LANGUAGE — USE THESE WORDS, NOT OTHERS

almost certainly 95–99% · very likely 80–95% · likely 55–80% · roughly even 45–55% · unlikely 20–45% · very unlikely 05–20% · remote 01–05%

Do not mix verbal and numeric in one sentence. Never "possible," "could," "may," or "might" as estimates. State *likelihood* and *confidence* (high / moderate / low) separately.

THE ERRORS WE ACTUALLY MAKE

- A missing bracket or p./pp. · a colon or comma in the wrong place · a shortened URL · a Journal Article with no review status · a rating assigned by category, not track record · three outlets repeating one anonymous official, counted as three · an Ibid. left pointing at the wrong note after a reorder · a screenshot cited as the post · an inferred geolocation given as metadata · a link never archived